The Odyssey

Annotated model · "The Lotus Eaters" (from Book 9) · Unit 2, Lesson 3

Homer, translated by Robert Fitzgerald · textbook page 721 · Challenge Accepted!

Learning targets

9.DSR I can read a challenging text closely, use strategies when my understanding breaks down, and give the line number where my evidence is.

9.RV.1.B I can use context clues and sentence structure to figure out the literal and figurative meanings of words and phrases.

9.RL.1.A I can explain a theme of the text and how its characters, setting, and plot develop that theme.

9.RL.3.B I can explain how the setting shapes the plot and the characters.

9.RL.2.B I can explain how word choice, tone, and the narrator's voice shape the meaning of the text.

EQ How do the challenges of life affect a person?

Reading the annotations

Vocabulary & figurative language a word to figure out from context 9.RV.1.B · blue notes

Theme a line that raises a topic that develops a theme 9.RL.1.A · red notes

Character · Setting · Plot a detail that builds a theme, or a setting that drives the plot 9.RL.1.A or 9.RL.3.B · red notes

Word choice · Tone · Voice how Homer's words shape meaning 9.RL.2.B · purple notes

Hero / leader pink underline: Odysseus acts as a hero or leader lesson code

Major event circled in red lesson code

★ **Clarify** a star where the note clarifies or explains lesson code

Blue notes define words and give the context clue. Red notes connect a detail to a theme; the number tells you which theme. Setting notes tagged 9.RL.3.B show the setting driving the plot or shaping a character; those tagged 9.RL.1.A show it building a theme. Purple notes explain an author's choice. Arrows point to the exact words, and each note ends with its SOL code.

Topic vs. theme. A topic names a subject (*temptation*). A theme carries a message about it (*giving in to temptation can cost you what matters most*). The numbered themes are listed at the top of page 1.

Citing evidence. Lines are numbered in fives. When you quote or paraphrase, give the line: (l. 19) or (lines 18–19).

The lesson's student codes. The model also uses the codes students use on their copies: a pink mark where Odysseus acts as a hero or leader, a circle around each major event, and a star where something is clarified or explained. Here the pink is an underline, so the colours underneath still show.

Themes

1. Giving in to temptation can cost you what matters most.
2. Comfort and pleasure can make you forget your goals.
3. Danger does not always look dangerous.
4. Life's challenges test a leader, who must make hard choices to keep the group on course.

from

The Odyssey

An Epic Poem by **Homer**

Translated by **Robert Fitzgerald**

The Lotus Eaters (from Book 9)

Odysseus is telling King Alcinous the story of his journey home from Troy. After the raid on the Cicones, where 72 of his men died, his ships set sail again for Ithaca.

"I might have made it safely home, that time, but as I came round Malea[1] the current took me out to sea, and from the north a fresh gale drove me on, past Cythera.[2] Nine days I drifted on the teeming sea before dangerous high winds. Upon the tenth we came to the coastline of the Lotus Eaters, who live upon that flower. We landed there to take on water.

1. **Malea** a cape at the southern tip of Greece.
2. **Cythera** an island off that cape.

Voice: first person "I"
Odysseus tells his own story, so he is its hero 9.RL.2.B

4. Setting: a storm at sea
The setting drives the plot: wind and current push them off course. 9.RL.3.B

3. Setting: a calm island
Peaceful after the storm, but danger does not always look dangerous. 9.RL.1.A

2. Topic: the goal of home
He is almost home. Watch what pulls them away. 9.RL.1.A

Vocab: gale = a very strong wind
clue: "high winds" (l. 6) 9.RV.1.B

4. Character: a patient leader
The sea is in control. Ride it out, or fight for home? 9.RL.3.B

4. Character: a caring leader
Water and a meal so the crew can recover. 9.RL.1.A

All ships' companies mustered alongside for
the mid-day meal. Then I sent out two
picked men and a runner to learn what race of
men that land sustained. They fell in, soon
enough, with Lotus Eaters, who showed no
will to do us harm, only offering the sweet
Lotus to our friends— but those who ate
this honeyed plant, the Lotus, never cared to
report, not to return:
they longed to stay forever, browsing on that
native bloom, forgetful of their homeland. I
drove them, all three wailing, to the ships,
tied them down under their rowing benches,
and called the rest: 'All hands aboard; come,
clear the beach and no one taste the Lotus, or
you lose your hope of home.' Filing in to their
places by the rowlocks my oarsmen
dipped their long oars in the surf, and we
moved out again on our sea faring."

Vocab: mustered = gathered
clue: "all ships' companies ... alongside" 9.RV.1.B

4. Character: a careful leader
He sends scouts before risking everyone. 72 men died at the Cicones. 9.RL.1.A

Vocab: sustained = fed, kept alive
clue: they "live upon that flower" (lines 7–8) 9.RV.1.B

1. Topic: temptation
Today: like drugs. Offered in a friendly way, they feel good at first, then you stop caring about your goals. 9.RL.1.A

3. Topic: hidden danger
No weapons, no attack. The threat is temptation, which is harder to see. 9.RL.1.A

Word choice: "sweet," "honeyed"
pleasant words make the trap feel safe 9.RL.2.B

1. Plot: the scouts eat the Lotus
The island's plant changes the men: they never report back. 9.RL.3.B

2. Topic: forgetting home
Pleasure makes them want to stay forever. Their goal is gone. 9.RL.1.A

Vocab: browsing = grazing, like cattle
clue: "on that native bloom" 9.RV.1.B

Word choice: "wailing"
grown men crying like children: the Lotus has changed them 9.RL.2.B

4. Character: a decisive leader
He drags the men back and ties them down: unpopular, but it saves them. 9.RL.1.A

4. Character: he protects the crew
Everyone off the beach before anyone else is tempted. 9.RL.1.A

1. Topic: the cost of temptation
He says the theme out loud: give in and you lose your hope of home. 9.RL.1.A

Vocab: rowlocks = oar holders
clue: "oarsmen dipped their long oars" 9.RV.1.B

4. Plot: back on course
The leader gets them moving again. Challenge passed, for now. 9.RL.1.A

Teacher notes

How the themes develop · discussion key · model response

How the themes develop

Beginning (lines 1–12). The goal is stated: *"safely home."* The setting supplies the first challenge, a storm that blows the ships off course for nine days, then brings them to a calm island. Odysseus is patient, caring, and careful: he waters and feeds the crew and scouts before risking everyone. Themes 4, 3

Middle (lines 13–19). The danger looks harmless: the Lotus Eaters show *"no will to do us harm."* The *"sweet," "honeyed"* plant tempts the scouts, who never return and become *"forgetful of their homeland."* Themes 1, 2, 3

End (lines 19–27). Odysseus drives the wailing men to the ships, ties them down, orders everyone aboard, and states the lesson: taste the Lotus and *"you lose your hope of home."* His hard choice gets them back on course. Themes 1, 4

Discussion key (slide notes)

Slide 20, I Do (lines 1–4). A storm throws Odysseus off his route home: a major event, because it takes him off course.

Slide 21, We Do (lines 4–6). Nine days adrift: accept either side with a reason. Smart not to fight a sea he can't beat, or he should have steered for home.

Slide 21, We Do (lines 6–10). Reaching the island is a major event; stopping for water and food lets the crew recover.

Slide 21, We Do (lines 10–17). The scouts eat the Lotus and never report back. Some will say this shows the men didn't respect him.

Slide 22, partners (lines 18–27, 7 min). He ties the crying men under the benches, forbids the Lotus, and gets the ships moving; still, some men no longer wanted to go home.

Slide 23, exit discussion. The storm keeps him from home and brings him to the island; the island's Lotus makes men stop wanting to leave, which forces Odysseus to act. 9.RL.3.B

Model response

In "The Lotus Eaters," Homer develops the theme that giving in to temptation can cost you what matters most. The setting drives the plot: a storm pushes the ships off course to an island where the people offer the *"sweet"* Lotus. Because the Lotus Eaters show *"no will to do us harm,"* the danger is easy to miss. The scouts who eat it become *"forgetful of their homeland,"* showing how pleasure can erase a goal. Odysseus's response completes the theme: he drags the men *"all three wailing"* to the ships and warns that anyone who tastes the Lotus will *"lose your hope of home."*

Watch for

Topic, not theme: push "temptation" to a full statement. **"The Lotus Eaters are villains":** they are not hostile; the danger is inside the men. **Modern connection (line 14):** the Lotus is offered kindly and tastes "sweet," like drugs passed around by friends; ask what the men lose (their goal, their way home) and what students could lose. **Who is telling this?** Odysseus narrates to King Alcinous, so he may make himself look like a better leader than he was. 9.RL.2.C